

Open source web servers vs proprietary web servers

Feature	Open source web servers	Proprietary web servers
Source code access	Source code is publicly available and modifiable.	Source code is closed, not accessible or modifiable.
Licensing	Free to use, modify, and distribute under open source licences (e.g., GPL, Apache License).	Requires purchase of a commercial licence for use.
Cost	Typically free, though there may be costs for support or customisation.	Requires purchasing a licence, often with ongoing costs for support and updates.
Support	Community-driven support via forums, documentation, and user groups.	Vendor-provided support, typically with paid plans and professional assistance.
Customisation	High flexibility, allowing users to modify and extend the server's features.	Limited customisation; modifications are often restricted or not allowed.
Vendor lock-in	No lock-in; users can switch freely between different open source solutions.	Vendor lock-in; switching providers can be complex and costly.
Scalability	Highly scalable with various configuration options suited for different workloads.	Scalable, but options may be limited by the software's design or licensing.

Best open source web servers for 2025

Apache HTTP Server

Apache HTTP Server, commonly known as Apache, is one of the oldest and most widely used web servers globally. It is highly customisable and has supported many advanced web technologies over the years.

Market share: Apache held a significant market share of around 25-30% in the web server market in 2024.

Main Features	
Modular architecture	Allows users to load specific features as needed.
Extensive documentation	Apache's community offers a comprehensive set of resources for developers.
Wide language support	Supports PHP, Perl, Python, and more.
Security features	Features like <i>mod_security</i> for enhanced security.
Customisable configurations	Allows advanced configuration through <i>.htaccess</i> files.

Ideal use cases

- **Enterprise applications:** Due to its flexibility and reliability, Apache is ideal for hosting enterprise-level websites.
- **Dynamic websites:** Supports PHP, Perl, and other server-side scripting languages.
- **Custom solutions:** Ideal for use cases requiring specific modules or extensive configuration control.

NGINX

NGINX is known for its speed and scalability. It is often used as a reverse proxy server due to its ability to handle a high volume of concurrent connections with minimal resource consumption.

Market share: NGINX holds a market share of approximately 30-35%, making it one of the leading web servers.

Main Features	
High performance	Optimised for serving static content with low latency.
Reverse proxy and load balancing	Can act as a reverse proxy and distribute traffic.
Asynchronous event-driven architecture	Non-blocking design allows handling more requests with fewer resources.
SSL/TLS offloading	Supports offloading encryption and decryption processes for improved performance.

Ideal use cases

- **High traffic websites:** Ideal for websites with high traffic and concurrent connections.
- **Reverse proxy:** Frequently used as a reverse proxy server to balance load.
- **Static content:** Best for delivering static content like images, videos, and HTML.